

Kenny (Ling) Miao

Department of Government, University of Texas at Austin

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Education

The University of Texas at Austin

expected May 2027

Ph.D. Candidate in Government

- Dissertation: *Surviving and Reviving: Religion and Politics in Authoritarian China*
- Committee: Xiaobo Lü (co-chair), John Gerring (co-chair), Kenneth F. Greene, Amy Liu, Anna Grzymała-Busse (external), and Fenggang Yang (external)

Duke University

2019

M.A. in Political Science

Wuhan University

2017

B.A. in Political Science

Research Interests

Religion and politics; authoritarian politics; Chinese politics; experimental methods; historical political economy

Dissertation and Book Project

My dissertation addresses the puzzle of how Protestant Christianity in China grew from one million followers in 1949 to about 40 million today, under a party-state committed to atheism. I argue that this growth stems from the unintended consequences of regime action and from strategic accommodation by religious leaders. The Party's state-building campaigns dismantled the clans that had governed the religious field, creating space for new religious actors; market reform generated the economic dislocation that fueled religious demand; and Christian leaders adapted their messaging to navigate social hostility and broaden their appeal. I test this argument with original experiments and surveys, an original county-level historical dataset, and fieldwork in more than 50 churches.

Publications

Kenny Miao. Accepted. "Searching for the Gods: Internet Search as a Measure of Religious Practice in China." *The China Quarterly*. [PDF]

- Presented at MPSA (2024), SSSR (2025)

Jason Brownlee and **Kenny Miao**. 2022. "Why Democracies Survive." *Journal of Democracy* 33(4): 133–149.

Under Review

“Preaching for Power: Consequences of Pro-Regime Propaganda by Religious Leaders.” **Kenny Miao**. [\[PDF\]](#)

– Best Student Paper Award, Society for the Scientific Study of Religion (2024)
– Presented at APSA (2024), Texas Comparative Circle (2024), SSSR (2024), and New Faces in Chinese Politics (2025)

“Reading the Room: Nationality-of-Sponsor Effects on Survey Responses in China.” **Kenny Miao** and Jay Kao. [\[PDF\]](#)

“Leader Tenure and Leader Power.” John Gerring, Andres Cruz, **Kenny Miao**, Erzen Öncel, and Harunobu Saijo. [\[PDF\]](#)

Working Papers

“Schools of Authority: How Religion Shapes Americans’ Trust in Institutions.” **Kenny Miao**. [\[PDF\]](#)

“Revolutions and Revivals: How State-Building Sparks New Religious Movements.” **Kenny Miao**. [\[PDF\]](#)

– Presented at MPSA (2025), APSA (2026)

“The Gentry and the Sectarian: Elite Status Preservation in Post-Imperial China.” **Kenny Miao**.

“Education and Selective Liberalism: Evidence from China.” **Kenny Miao** and Jay Kao.

– Presented at IPSA (2025)

Work in Progress

“Mapping the Hidden Sacred: Religious Venues and the Local Policy Environment in China.” **Kenny Miao** and Fenggang Yang.

“Beyond the Congregation: Church Institutionalization and Social Trust.” **Kenny Miao**.

“*Leader Tenure Through History*.” John Gerring, Andres Cruz, **Kenny Miao**, Erzen Öncel, and Harunobu Saijo.

Book Project

Surviving and Reviving: Religion and Politics in Authoritarian China. **Kenny Miao**.

Grants, Awards, and Fellowships

External

Best Student Paper, Society for the Scientific Study of Religion	2024
Student Research Grant, Society for the Scientific Study of Religion	2024
Student Research Grant, Institute for Humane Studies	2024

University of Texas at Austin

Graduate School Semester Fellowship	2025
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Texas Politics Project Grant	2024
Graduate School Summer Fellowship	2023, 2024
Pre-dissertation Fellowship	2022
ICPSR Sponsorship	2022

Teaching

University of Texas at Austin

As (co-)instructor

Math in Politics	Fall 2023
Math Camp for Graduate Students	2021, 2022

As teaching assistant

Chinese Politics	Spring 2024
Introduction to American Government	Spring 2021, Spring 2022
Suicide Terrorism	Fall 2021
U.S. Foreign Policy	Fall 2019, Spring 2020, Fall 2020

Professional Experience

Elephant Magazine (Beijing, China), Columnist	2019–2020
Caixin Media (Beijing, China), Columnist	2018–2020

Service and Leadership

Editorial Assistant, APSR	2025–2027
Co-president, Government Graduate Student Organization, UT Austin	2023–2024

Training and Skills

Additional training: Text Analysis, ICPSR Summer Program 2022

Languages: Chinese (native), English (fluent)

Software: R, Stata, $\text{\LaTeX}$, Qualtrics

References

Xiaobo Lü (co-chair) Associate Professor Department of Political Science UC Berkeley xiaobo.lu@berkeley.edu	John Gerring (co-chair) Professor Department of Government UT Austin jgerring@austin.utexas.edu	Kenneth F. Greene Associate Professor Department of Government UT Austin kgreene@austin.utexas.edu
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